

racehorse breeder in Pune. In 1966, he set up the Serum Institute of India (SII) to manufacture vaccines inexpensively and then went on to grow the facility into one of the world's largest. Adar joined the family business in 2001 after completing his education at a private school in England and getting a degree in business management from the University of Westminster. In 2011, he was anointed CEO and in the past decade has expanded the business to 140 countries. Now, 85 per cent of SII's revenues (Rs 5,200 crore in 2019-20) come from the overseas market.

Before the pandemic struck, Adar Poonawalla was more in the news for his flamboyant lifestyle, which included driving to work in a Rolls Royce Phantom and converting a retired A 320 aircraft into his corporate camp office at SII's new manufacturing facility on the outskirts of Pune. When he is not immersed in the business, along with wife Natasha, a London School of Economics graduate and fashionista, Poonawalla flits between Pune, Mumbai and London hobnobbing with the crème de la crème of society. In marked contrast, Ella drives to work in a Toyota Innova or Tata Hexa, retains his middle-class roots and shuns the high life. His only passion is his research interests. Ella is something of a foodie, however, and has branched out into manufacturing his own brand of spices and nuts, employing sophisticated technology, including cryogenic grinding to retain their authentic flavours and ensure that they meet the stringent safety standards for exports. What Ella and Poonawalla, along with their wives, have in common is a commitment to philanthropic activities. The Ellas run a foundation for identifying talented young researchers and nurturing them. The Poonawallas have a trust that focuses on the health, water, sanitation and education needs of the underprivileged, which Natasha heads, apart from a cleanliness drive for Pune, which is Adar's passion.

When the pandemic broke out in India in March 2020, both Ella and Poonawalla would find themselves at the forefront of the country's desperate drive to develop and manufacture vaccines that could battle Covid-19 (Coronavirus Disease-19) and reduce its debilitating health impacts. With the help of SII and BBIL, India, which launched its vaccination programme in early 2021, was able to inject a record 1.4 billion doses of vaccine to its adult population by December 27. In doing so, both Ella and Adar Poonawalla became heroes in the battle to thwart Covid-19 and were lauded for making Indians feel safer and saving lives. Dr V.K. Paul, Niti Aayog member and chairperson of the National Expert Group on Vaccine Administration for Covid-19 (NEGVAC), says, "With their combined efforts, they helped avert a health catastrophe and demonstrated to the world that India has the academic, scientific and industrial depth to make Covid-19 vaccines that meet the highest standards of the world and do it at a highly competitive speed."

This is no mean achievement. For when the first wave of the pandemic struck the country, Paul in April 2020 had told INDIA TODAY: "The bad way of getting through this pandemic is allowing a majority to get infected by the virus and thereby achieve herd immunity. The cost in terms of life and health would be enormous. The good way to get through this crisis is to develop vaccines against the virus." But that was easier said than done. Experience suggested that an effective vaccine would take anything